

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 769

By Vital

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Harry Austin of
Chattanooga.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Harry Austin; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Austin was a highly respected journalist and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for his fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, a Chattanooga native born on April 2, 1946, Harry Austin began his journalism career as a high school student, working part time at *The Chattanooga Times* while also playing football at Central High School; his early employment with the newspaper enabled him to attend the University of Chattanooga, now the University of Tennessee at Chattanooga; and

WHEREAS, after college, Mr. Austin worked for two years as a general assignment reporter, then as a police reporter, covering crime; after saving enough money for travel, he spent the next five years exploring Africa, Europe, and Asia, making lifelong friends and sometimes stopping to work along the way; and

WHEREAS, back in Tennessee, Harry Austin returned to newspaper reporting, covering general assignments along with the crime and county government beats while demonstrating the rigor and compassion that would later define his editorial work; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Austin left the newspaper to serve with the Tennessee Valley Authority in 1980, further broadening his understanding of public institutions and regional issues, experience he would later bring back into the newsroom; and

WHEREAS, eight years later, Harry Austin returned to *The Chattanooga Times* as an opinion writer, and, following the merger of *The Chattanooga Times* and the *Chattanooga Free*

Press into today's *Chattanooga Times Free Press*, he became editor of the newspaper's opinion page, a post he held with distinction until his retirement in 2013; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Austin received numerous awards and recognitions during his illustrious career; he was active in the National Conference of Editorial Writers for many years and participated in the Robert Bosch Stiftung German-American Journalists exchange program promoting international understanding; and

WHEREAS, Harry Austin's true passion was spending time in the saddle on his quarter horse, Tango, exploring trails with his friends; he loved the outdoors and appreciated the beauty of nature, riding in local parks and forests most weekends and often participating in cattle drives and livestock management in the West; and

WHEREAS, left to cherish his memory are his loving partner, Kristy Huntley; daughters, Karina Allison and Leslie (Josh) Rust; grandson, Michael Rust; sister, Sybil Clark; brother, Ed Austin; and a host of extended family members, colleagues, and dear friends; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Austin was preceded in death by his parents, James H. Austin, Sr., and Oberia Austin; and

WHEREAS, Harry Austin leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Harry Austin, reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mr. Austin.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.